

University of Baltimore

III-1.2 Email Guidelines

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Introduction

The University of Baltimore has adopted a University-wide policy intended to describe appropriate use of electronic mail (email). The purpose of these guidelines is to recommend procedures and tips for effective adherence to the Email Policy.

I. Appropriate content and tone:

Email should be thoughtfully written, carefully edited, and sent only to appropriate recipients. Users should remember common courtesy and respect for others. Think before clicking "Send". Email is the modern form of writing a letter, so the writer should use similar standards for email. Do not say anything in an email that you would not want to put in writing on paper, permanently. Ask yourself: Would I say this in person?

Never send email when angry or exhausted. Try not to reply immediately to a message that upsets you. Save your thoughts in writing and look at them the next day. Sometimes, upon reflection, you may rewrite the message and improve the tone, and sometimes, you may not need to send the message at all.

The University cannot, in general, protect users from receiving email that they may find offensive. Members of the University community, however, are strongly encouraged to use the same personal and professional courtesies and considerations in email as they would in other forms of communication.

II. Determine whether Email is the right medium.

Evaluate whether face-to-face, telephone, or formal written communication is more appropriate. The best use of the email medium is as a substitute for a conversation where information is being exchanged, and the topic is not controversial or sensitive. Since the possibility of misinterpreting tone is much greater with the written than with the spoken word, some communications are better handled with a phone call or a conversation. Sensitive matters are better left to direct communication. Avoid using email to reprimand, reward, or terminate someone who reports to you. If your object is to persuade someone to do something, email is not an adequate substitute for an in-person meeting.

III. Privacy: UB's Email Policy states

"Because of the nature of electronic communication, the University can assure neither the complete privacy of an individual's use of the University's email resources nor the confidentiality of particular messages."

Employees should have no expectation of privacy in anything they create, store, send, or receive on the computer system. Keep in mind that anything you create or store on the computer system may be reviewed by others. Remember, for example, that email can be copied and forwarded with ease. A reply on a discussion list or listserv can be sent inadvertently to all readers of the listserv, rather than to the individual it was intended for. Email is not easily deleted; it may live on in University backup facilities or be indefinitely stored for litigation hold or other University operations.

UBalt's Email Policy also states that "The University may, however, deny access to its email services and may inspect, monitor, or disclose electronic mail ... (See V-2) ... when required for the orderly conduct of University operations." While it is impossible to identify all circumstances under which this clause will apply, users should expect it to be invoked frequently, for routine system housekeeping, such as blocking accounts that exceed their storage quotas; occasionally, when required to preserve or repair the system, such as removing phishing messages or attachments deemed likely to carry viruses; and rarely, to retrieve vital content, such as payroll information, that might have been sent to the email account of an absent manager.

IV. Security:

Sensitive or confidential information must be handled with care and according to organization policy. If it is something that you would not say with a third party listening, then you should avoid writing it in an email message. When you need to protect the privacy of an email message, encrypt it. Encrypting an email message in Outlook means it's converted from readable plain text into a message that only the recipient can view. Contact OTS if you need assistance with encrypting an email message. Social Security Numbers, credit card numbers, and other sensitive information should not be sent through email even with encryption enabled.

V. Tips and Tricks

- Users are encouraged to organize email upon receipt. Save important messages to word processor files or some other reliable medium.
- To handle the overload of incoming email, scan subject headers and delete everything not relevant to you or your work.
- Create an email signature in Outlook to save time by not having to retype your name and address. Keep an up-to-date address book.
- Use the out of office feature.